

Vahid Moghani

Postdoctoral Researcher, Erasmus School of Economics and Tinbergen Institute

vahid-moghani.com · moghani@ese.eur.nl

Erasmus School of Economics, Burg. Oudlaan 50, 3062 PA Rotterdam, The Netherlands

Academic Positions	Postdoctoral Researcher	2024 - 2027
	Erasmus School of Economics and Tinbergen Institute Visiting Researcher, Institute for Fiscal Studies , London	Spring 2026
Education	Ph.D.	2019 - 2024
	Erasmus School of Economics and Tinbergen Institute Visiting Graduate Student, Brown University , Providence	Spring 2024
	Supervisors: Pilar García-Gómez and Tom Van Ourti	
	MPhil in Economics	2017 - 2019
	Major in Econometrics Graduated with Distinction Tinbergen Institute	
	M.Sc. in Economics	2014 - 2017
	Sharif University of Technology	
	B.Sc. in Aerospace Engineering	2008 - 2013
	Minor in Mathematics	
	Sharif University of Technology	
Research Interests	Health economics, labor economics, and econometrics (causal inference, measurement, and statistical learning)	

Working Papers	The Health Costs of Firms (<i>Job Market Paper</i>) Single-authored. [paper] R package: LeaveOutKSS <i>Abstract.</i> This paper estimates how much firms differ in their contribution to otherwise similar workers' healthcare expenditure. Using linked Dutch employer-employee data, I exploit worker moves across firms to separate persistent worker and firm differences. Moving the same worker to a firm one standard deviation higher in the firm-effect distribution raises expected annual expenditure by 17.8%. The implied top-bottom quintile gap is comparable to gradients by income, wealth, and education, and over half of the dispersion lies within narrowly defined industries. Supporting a health-risk interpretation, workers who move to firms with higher coworker expenditure increase use of pain, anti-inflammatory, and muscle relaxant medications, and exposure to high-effect firms predicts disability and mortality, including among workers displaced by closures. High-effect firms pay higher wage premia, but mainly between rather than within industries. Because basic healthcare is collectively financed, the results point to a fiscal externality: firms generate healthcare expenditure they do not fully bear.
	When Is the Mover-Design Event Study Coefficient a Place-Effect Share? (<i>Companion Paper to the Job Market Paper</i>) Single-authored. [paper] Tinbergen Institute Discussion Paper 26-056. <i>Abstract.</i> Mover-design event studies are a leading approach to separating place effects from sorting. The coefficient is often interpreted as the share of cross-sectional variation in location means due to places. I show the coefficient depends on how movers connect locations: two economies can be identical in place effects, sorting, and location means, yet deliver different mover coefficients. Only under <i>directional isotropy</i> , a testable condition, does the coefficient permit a cross-sectional reading: it averages the variance share of place effects and the share that equalizing them removes. An illustration in Dutch employer-employee wage data rejects the condition.

Disambiguating Information Interventions: Recovering Beliefs and Ambiguity Attitudes from Virtual Twins

With Aurélien Baillon and Francesco Capozza. [\[paper\]](#)

Abstract. Elicited probabilities conflate latent beliefs, ambiguity attitudes, and response error. We develop a measurement method that identifies these components from noisy subjective-probability data using consequential bets on singleton and union events. Ambiguity weighting is parameterized by two indices (a, b) , capturing insensitivity and elevation. A hierarchical Bayesian model places latent beliefs on the simplex, allows respondent-level (a_i, b_i) , and treats elicited probabilities as noisy measurements. We implement the method in a randomized information experiment in the Dutch LISS panel, where respondents make incentivized forecasts about a demographically matched virtual twin's GP utilization. The treatment effect on raw probabilities is imprecise and indistinguishable from zero. Model-recovered beliefs show meaningful updating, improving predictive accuracy by 0.026 to 0.032 Brier points and lowering elevation-based ambiguity aversion, with a smaller and less robust change in likelihood insensitivity. Treatment effects on elicited probabilities need not identify treatment effects on beliefs.

Mental Health Literacy, Beliefs and Demand for Support among University Students (*Revise & Resubmit, Experimental Economics*)

With Michelle Acampora and Francesco Capozza. [\[paper\]](#)

Abstract. This paper assesses the impact of a mental health literacy intervention on the demand for mental health support among university students. We run a field experiment with 2,978 students at a large Dutch university. The intervention raises willingness to pay and demand for a mental-health app among male respondents, and shifts information demand from psychological counselling toward coaching, driven by students with moderate distress. Increased perceived effectiveness of low-intensity therapy appears to be the mechanism. A three-week follow-up suggests a moderate improvement in mental-health scores for treated female students, consistent with higher care-seeking.

Combining Boundary and Interior Information in Ordered Multi-Threshold Regression Discontinuity Designs

With Saeed Badri. [\[paper\]](#) Simulation code: [\[GitHub\]](#)

Abstract. Ordered multi-threshold regression discontinuity designs often require aggregating local discontinuities across several known cutoffs. This paper shows that such aggregate parameters can be decomposed into boundary terms and smooth contrasts between adjacent thresholds. Interior observations do not identify a single RD jump, but they are informative about these smooth segment contrasts. We develop an integrated-derivative estimator for segment contrasts by numerically integrating nonparametric estimates of the derivative of the conditional mean between adjacent thresholds. We derive its asymptotic distribution, including the leading bias and a feasible variance formula. The main result shows that the integrated-derivative estimator is asymptotically independent of the corresponding boundary-level estimator for the same smooth contrast. This independence yields a transparent inverse-variance combination of boundary and interior signals. The combined estimator is an augmentation of boundary-level estimation and is most useful when boundary information is sparse or noisy. Simulations confirm the distributional approximation and show modest gains under regular designs and larger gains in sparse-boundary designs.

Childhood Mental Health Effects of Early-Life Exposure to a Parental Job Loss (*Draft available upon request*)

With Pilar García-Gómez and Tom Van Ourti.

Abstract. We study the mental health effects of early life exposure to paternal job loss. Using nationwide individual-level administrative register records, we focus on firm-closure-induced job losses for fathers with children below age five in the Netherlands. These children are more likely to take mental health-related medicines in their later childhood, and this increase is mainly driven by psychostimulant drugs. The increased uptake of psychostimulants ranges from 15 percent of mean uptake in the control group at age five to around 9 percent at age twelve. The effects are significantly larger for families with mothers being the main breadwinner, suggesting that the drop in paternal income resulting from displacement is not the main driver of psychostimulant uptake. We further find that the father is more likely to take mental health medication around the time of job loss, and that the children exposed to paternal job loss are more likely to live in dissolved families. We find no evidence of exposed children living in neighborhoods with different rates of psychostimulant consumption compared to control children, while parents of treated children do report more impulsive behavior and inattention symptoms.

Publications	• Antipsychotic Exposure and Pharmacologically Treated Type 2 Diabetes in Dutch Youths (with R. N. Gangapersad, P. García-Gómez, B. C. P. Koch, B. Dierckx), <i>JAMA Network Open</i>, 2026.
Work in Progress	• Mental Models of Mental Health (with <i>S. Bhalotra</i> and <i>F. Capozza</i>) • Female Practice Ownership and Women’s Care: Evidence from Local Variation in Practice Owners (with <i>E. de Weerd</i>) • Do Patients or Physicians Drive Variation in Medication Costs in India? (with <i>A. Bhaskarabhatla</i>, <i>O. O’Donnell</i> and <i>S. Thakur</i>) • Dutch Colorectal Cancer Screening Program: Policy Learning under Equality Concerns and Capacity Constraints (with <i>I. Lansdorp-Vogelaar</i>, <i>O. O’Donnell</i>, <i>M. Robson</i>, <i>E. Toes-Zoutendijk</i>, <i>R. Van Gestel</i> and <i>T. Van Ourti</i>)
Software & Reproducibility	• LeaveOutKSS (CRAN): R package implementing leave-out (KSS) variance/covariance estimators for AKM two-way fixed effects (Kline, Saggio & Sølvsten, <i>Econometrica</i>, 2020).
Advanced Training (selected)	• CEMFI: Experiments in Complex Systems (Stefan Wager) and Unstructured Data (Stephen Hansen) • Tinbergen Institute: Causal Inference & ML (Guido Imbens) and Measure Theory & Asymptotics (Peter Spreij) • University of Amsterdam: Asymptotic Statistics (Bas Kleijn)
Grants	• Erasmus Initiative “Smarter Choices for Better Health” (Co-applicant), <i>Socioeconomic determinants of psychotropic medication use in children and adolescents</i>, €150,000, 2022-2026. • Seed Grant Scheme, Erasmus Initiative “Smarter Choices for Better Health”, data access for <i>Dutch Colorectal Cancer Screening Program: Policy Learning under Equality Concerns and Capacity Constraints</i>, €15,000, December 2024. • LISS Panel Grant (in-kind data collection), <i>Measuring Uncertainty Perception in the Health Domain</i>, 2024 (with A. Baillon and F. Capozza). • EsCHER Event Funding (Erasmus Centre for Health Economics Rotterdam), organization of the <i>4th Dutch Health Econometrics Workshop</i>, €1,500, 2026. • Building New Blocks (Co-lead with F. Capozza), <i>Information and Demand for Mental Health Support among University Students</i>, €5,000, 2021.

Presentations	2026: EEA-ESEM Congress, 31st International Panel Data Conference (IPDC), American-European Health Economics Study Group (X Edition), and an invited seminar at emlyon business school. 2025: European Economic Association Congress and an invited talk at the University of Basel. 2024: European Society for Population Economics, European Workshop on Econometrics and Health Economics, and Second Dutch Health Econometrics Workshop. 2023: ifo Dresden Workshop on Labor Economics and Social Policy and IZA Summer School in Labor Economics. 2022: IRDES-Dauphine AHEPE Workshop, EUHEA, Essen Economics of Mental Health Workshop, and ESE Young Staff Workshop (with Guido Imbens). 2021: Barcelona GSE Summer Forum, ASHEcon, and AES-APES VECR. 2020: Essen Economics of Mental Health Workshop and Essen Health Economics Conference.		
Teaching	Practical AI for Research: Large Language Models and Unstructured Data (Organizer and Lecturer), ERIM Summer Course, Erasmus University Rotterdam Seminar in Health Economics (Lecturer), Erasmus School of Economics Economics of the Welfare State (Lecturer), Erasmus School of Economics Economics of the Welfare State (Tutorial Leader), Erasmus School of Economics Microeconomics I (Teaching Assistant), Tinbergen Institute	2026 2024-present 2021-2023 2019-2020 2018	Summer Spring Fall Fall Fall
Service & Organization	Co-organizer and scientific committee member, 4th Dutch Health Econometrics Workshop, Erasmus University Rotterdam, September 2026. Referee: <i>The Economic Journal</i>, <i>Journal of Health Economics</i>, <i>Health Economics</i>. PhD Council (2022) and PhD Wellbeing Working Group (2021), Erasmus School of Economics.		
Honours & Awards	<i>Teaching Assistant of the Year Prize at Tinbergen Institute</i> <i>Ranked 6th of over 40,000 in the National M.Sc. Entrance Exam in Economics</i> <i>Ranked in the Top 1% of the National B.Sc. Entrance Exam</i>	2019 2014 2008	
References	Pilar García-Gómez Professor of Applied Economics Erasmus School of Economics garciaagomez@ese.eur.nl Sonia Bhalotra Professor of Economics University of Warwick Sonia.Bhalotra@warwick.ac.uk Aurélien Baillon Professor of Economics emlyon business school baillon@em-lyon.com Tom Van Ourti Professor of Applied Health Economics Erasmus School of Economics & ESHPM vanourti@ese.eur.nl Owen O'Donnell Professor of Applied Economics Erasmus School of Economics & ESHPM odonnell@ese.eur.nl		